



Young companions
The aging Gandhi is seen here with his “walking sticks”—his great-nieces Manu and Ava—at Birla House in New Delhi.

commitment in 1917 to progress toward a degree of Indian self-rule, and simultaneous oppression by the British authorities in the Raj, notably the massacre of 379 demonstrators at Amritsar in April 1919. In a very

short time, Gandhi swept to the forefront of Indian political life, launching a campaign of total noncooperation with the British, and a boycott of British goods, which attracted mass support. After taking over leadership of the Indian National Congress, he made it into a vital nationwide organization.

Spiritual values

Gandhi never had a politician's attitude, however. His goal was not the attainment of power but the spiritual and moral transformation of Indian society. His advocacy of nonviolence ran into difficulty as early as 1922, when a nationalist mob killed 22 policemen at Chauri Chaura, northern India. Gandhi responded by calling off his first noncooperation campaign, but critics pointed out in following years



Meeting the viceroy
Lord Mountbatten, the last British viceroy (governor) of India, and his wife were on close terms with Gandhi during the period preceding Indian independence in 1947.

that when he stirred up political dissent, in practice, it always led to violence. For much of the 1920s and 1930s Gandhi focused on breaking down communal barriers between Hindus and Muslims, and overthrowing the Hindu caste system—a system of inherited social classes. He also campaigned against industrialization, himself learning to use a hand spinning wheel as a symbol of his great belief in village crafts.

An undisputed leader

Despite these challenges, Gandhi remained both nationally and internationally the most renowned leader of the Indian independence movement. No other Indian leader could have led such an effective protest as the famous “Salt March” of 1930, a symbolic defiance of the British tax on salt. No other leader talked so effectively to the British ruling class, who were fascinated by his exotic dress and manner. And his moral authority in India was immense.

In 1942, reluctantly, he launched the “Quit India” movement, provoking brutal repression from the British authorities. The drift of events saddened his final years. The British decided to grant India independence after World War II, but the rise of Muslim separatism led to partition between India and Pakistan (see pp.410–411), which Gandhi loathed. Even worse

was the violence that the subcontinent was plunged into. Fasting and pleading with Hindus and Muslims, Gandhi occasionally managed to halt the slaughter in one place, only for it to break out in another. His conciliatory attitude toward Muslims enraged Hindu extremists. On January 20, 1948 he was shot dead in Delhi by Hindu fanatic Nathuram Godse.

“Truth never damages a cause that is just.”

GANDHI, FROM “NONVIOLENCE IN PEACE AND WAR,” 1948

TIMELINE

- **October 2, 1869** Gandhi is born in Porbandar, Gujarat.
- **May 1883** Is married, at age 13, to 10-year-old Kasturba Makhanji.
- **1888–91** Studies law at University College, London, and returns to India as a lawyer.
- **April 1893** Travels to Durban, South Africa, to join an Indian law firm.
- **1894** Begins 20 years of campaigning against discrimination and exploitation of Indians in South Africa.
- **1899–1902** During the Boer War, Gandhi forms an Indian Ambulance Corps.
- **September 11, 1906** Calls for resistance to the registration of Indians in Transvaal, initiating his first campaign of *satyagraha*.
- **May 1915** Returning to India, he founds the Satyagraha Ashram at Ahmedabad.
- **December 1921** Elected leader of the Indian National Congress.
- **February 1922** Halts the noncooperation campaign in shock at mob violence.
- **March 1922** Arrested and tried for sedition. Gandhi is sentenced to six years and serves two.
- **December 1928** Congress launches a campaign for dominion status for India.
- **January 26, 1930** Millions of Indians take Gandhi's pledge to pursue “*purna swaraj*”—complete independence.
- **March 12–April 6, 1930** Leads the “Salt March” from Ahmedabad to Dandi; he is arrested on May 4.
- **February 14–March 5, 1931** Released from prison. Gandhi negotiates a pact with British viceroy Lord Irwin to end civil disobedience.
- **September–December 1931** Gandhi represents Congress at a Round Table Conference on Indian constitutional reform in London; on his return to India he is arrested.
- **October 24, 1934** Disillusioned with politics, he resigns from Congress.
- **August 9, 1942** Gandhi and Congress leaders are arrested after the launch of the “Quit India” movement for independence from Britain; Gandhi is held in the Aga Khan Palace near Poona.
- **November 1946** Begins a solitary campaign to halt massacres and seek conciliation between Hindus and Muslims.
- **January 30, 1948** Gandhi is assassinated at Birla House, New Delhi.



GANDHI AT HIS LAW OFFICES



NEWSPAPER REPORT OF GANDHI'S DEATH

IDEA

SATYAGRAHA

Gandhi's principle of *satyagraha*, a nonviolent political struggle, was influential after his death. It became, for example, a point of reference for Martin Luther King Jr. as leader of the American civil rights movement (see pp.432–33), for the founders of the Campaign for Nuclear Disarmament (CND), and for some within the anti-Vietnam War protest movement (see pp.430–31). For Gandhi, *satyagraha* was more than simply a way of achieving political objectives through civil disobedience. He saw it as a path to spiritual improvement through truth, love, and suffering.

